



THE CONTRACTOR'S FIELD GUIDE TO CLAUDE

A plain-English playbook for sitework, landscape, irrigation, hardscape, and concrete pros who'd rather be running a job than fighting with software.

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Pick one painful task — the whole strategy

Prepared by Takeoff Monkey for our contractor customers. You don't need to be "techy" to use any of this — if you can text, send an email, and take a photo on your phone, you already have every skill required. Skim it, find what's useful, ignore the rest.

BEFORE WE START

READ THIS PART FIRST

You don't need to be "techy" to use any of this. Claude is just a really sharp assistant that you talk to in plain English — the same way you'd talk to a foreman who happens to know computers.

Here's the one rule that matters: **you don't have to know the right words.** You don't have to say "generate a spreadsheet using a connector." You can say "make me a list of my material costs and put it in a spreadsheet." Claude figures out the rest.

This guide walks through what Claude can do, with real examples from the trades. The five big ideas build on each other — plain chat, then connectors, then skills, then agents, then plugins — but you can start anywhere and ignore the rest until you need it.

The whole idea in one sentence

You describe what you need done in plain words, and Claude does the work — or hands back a real, finished file you can open, print, email, or give to a client.

The five ways to use it, simplest to most powerful

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|---------------------|---|
| • Chat | Type or talk, get an answer. No setup. Estimating help, writing, reading documents, quick math. |
| • Connectors | Claude reaches into apps you already use — email, calendar, file storage, project boards — so you stop copying and pasting. |
| • Skills | Claude produces actual files — a bid spreadsheet, a Word proposal, a slide deck, a filled-out PDF. |
| • Agents | Hand off a whole multi-step job and let Claude run it start to finish, then come back when it's done. |
| • Plugins | Bolt-on toolkits aimed at one type of work — marketing, sales pipeline, data, and more. |

SECTION 01

THE BASICS — JUST TALKING TO CLAUDE

At its simplest, Claude is a chat. You type or talk, it answers. No setup. Here's what that's good for on day one.

Estimating and takeoff help

- "I'm bidding a 2-acre commercial site. Walk me through every cost category I should make sure I didn't forget."
- "A cubic yard of concrete covers how much area at 4 inches thick? I need to pour a 40x60 pad."
- "My sub quoted \$14,500 for irrigation on a 1.5 acre property. Does that sound high, low, or about right, and what questions should I ask him?"
- "Help me figure out how many tons of #57 stone I need for a parking area 120 ft by 80 ft, 6 inches deep."

Writing the stuff you hate writing

- "Write a professional but firm email to a GC who hasn't paid an invoice that's 45 days late."
- "Turn these rough notes into a clean scope of work for my proposal." (then paste your notes)
- "Draft a change order for added drainage work, \$3,200, because we hit clay we didn't expect."
- "Write a polite text to a homeowner explaining we're delayed two days because of rain."

Understanding documents

- "Here's a 30-page spec section. Tell me in plain English what the compaction requirements are."
- "Read this subcontract and flag anything that could screw me — payment terms, retainage, indemnification, that kind of thing."

You can paste text, upload a PDF, or snap a photo of a printed page. Claude reads all of it.

Quick jobsite math and answers

- "What's the fall over 200 feet at a 2% grade?"
- "OSHA trench depth where I need a protective system — refresh me."
- "Convert 5,400 square feet to acres."

SECTION 02

CONNECTORS

A connector lets Claude talk to apps you already use — your email, your calendar, your file storage, your project boards. Once connected, you stop copying and pasting. You just ask.

Think of it like giving your assistant the keys to the filing cabinet instead of reading every document to them out loud. These are the common ones for a contracting business.

Email — Gmail / Outlook

- "Find the email where the architect sent the revised site plan last week."
- "Summarize everything the GC on the Maple Street job has emailed me this month."
- "Draft replies to the three bid invitations in my inbox, but don't send them — let me review first."

Calendar — Google Calendar / Outlook

- "What walkthroughs and bid deadlines do I have this week?"
- "Block two hours Thursday morning for the Riverside takeoff."

File storage — Google Drive / Dropbox

- "Find the as-built drawings for the Henderson project."
- "Pull up last year's pricing sheet for retaining wall block."

Project boards — Monday.com, Notion, and more

- "Add a new job to my board: Oakwood Plaza, bid due the 14th, est. \$180K."
- "Which of my active jobs are missing a start date?"

A note on permissions. Claude will read freely, but for anything that does something out in the world — sending an email, posting publicly, deleting files, spending money — it asks you first every time. You're always the one who hits "send." Connectors get turned on in your settings menu; if one you want isn't there, that's where you'd add it.

SKILLS

A skill is a packaged set of know-how Claude pulls in automatically when your task calls for it. You don't turn these on or even name them — Claude reaches for the right one the way a good hand grabs the right tool without being told.

The most useful ones for you produce actual files.

Spreadsheets (Excel)

- "Build me a bid spreadsheet with columns for line item, quantity, unit, unit cost, total, and markup. Add a row that sums the grand total."
- "Here's a messy CSV export from my accounting software. Clean it up and total my material costs by category."
- "Make me a labor tracking sheet — crew member, hours, rate, day of week, with weekly totals."

Word documents

- "Turn my proposal into a clean Word document with my company header, a scope section, pricing table, and signature line."
- "Create a safety meeting sign-in sheet I can print."

PowerPoint

- "Make a 6-slide capabilities presentation I can show a GC who's never used us — what we do, projects we've done, our equipment, why pick us."

PDFs

- "Fill out this PDF lien waiver with the project info I'm about to give you."
- "Merge these three PDF invoices into one file."

The point

You describe the deliverable in plain words, and a real, finished file comes back that you can open, print, email, or hand to a client.

AGENTS

Everything above is back-and-forth chat. An agent is when you hand Claude a multi-step task and let it run the whole thing — research, pull files, do the work, assemble the result — and come back when it's done. Like delegating a project to a competent office manager instead of answering questions one at a time.

A few Claude products are built around this.

Claude Cowork

For heavier office work that spans a lot of steps and files. Good for things like:

- "Go through all my bids from the last six months, pull out which ones I won and lost, and tell me if there's a pattern in the ones I'm losing."
- "Research the three GCs I'm thinking about pursuing — size, the kind of work they do, anything about how they pay — and write me a one-pager on each."

Claude Code

For anyone building the kind of automation that connects your tools together (the bid-tracker-talks-to-your-calendar-talks-to-your-email type of thing). If you've got someone semi-technical on staff, this is their playground. Most contractors won't touch it directly, and that's fine.

Claude in Chrome

A browsing assistant that can actually click around websites for you:

- "Go to the county permit portal and find the requirements for a grading permit in this jurisdiction."
- "Pull the current diesel price from these three supplier sites and compare them."

Claude on your phone

All of this works from the mobile app, which matters when your office is the cab of a truck. Snap a photo of a hand-marked plan and ask for a takeoff. Dictate a change order from the jobsite. Check your bid deadlines from the gravel lot.

SECTION 05

PLUGINS & FEATURES WORTH KNOWING

A plugin is a bundle of related skills aimed at one type of work. Turn it on and Claude gains a focused set of abilities. You won't need all of them — most contractors do fine with one or two.

• Marketing tools	Draft social posts, write a company newsletter, plan content, review your website's search ranking. Useful if you're trying to win work without a marketing person.
• Sales / pipeline tools	Research a company before a bid meeting, prep for a call with a GC, track which opportunities are going stale.
• Data tools	Turn your job history into charts and dashboards, find what's driving your margins up or down.
• Web research tools	Pull pricing or product specs off supplier sites in bulk.

A few features worth knowing about

Memory

Claude can remember context about your business across conversations — your company name, how you like proposals formatted, your typical markup — so you stop re-explaining yourself. You control what it remembers and can tell it to forget anything.

Search past chats

"Pull up that conversation where we worked out the drainage detail for the Carter job." It'll find it.

Projects

A way to keep all the chats and files for one job (or one part of your business) in their own bucket, so the bidding stuff doesn't get tangled up with the marketing stuff.

Web search

Claude checks the live web when something might have changed — current material prices, a code update, who owns a company now — instead of guessing from memory.

Artifacts and visuals

Ask for a chart, a diagram, or a simple calculator and it builds it right there in the chat.

"Make me a quick tool where I plug in length, width, and depth and it spits out cubic yards of concrete."

SECTION 06

HOW A NON-TECHY CONTRACTOR GETS STARTED

Don't try to do all of this. Pick one painful task and start there. Here are five good first moves — in roughly the order most contractors find them.

- 1 Next time you write a proposal,** paste your rough notes and say "clean this into a professional scope of work." That alone will sell you on it.
- 2 Next time you're staring at a spec,** paste the confusing section and ask for it in plain English.
- 3 Connect your email** and ask Claude to summarize what a particular GC has sent you. Watch it save you 20 minutes of scrolling.
- 4 Next bid spreadsheet,** describe the columns you want and let Claude build it.
- 5 When something works,** do it again next week. That's the whole strategy.

The test for what to start with

If a task is repetitive, takes time you'd rather spend on the job, and doesn't require your hard-won judgment — that's the one to hand to Claude first.



THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER

THE TECH IS THE EASY PART.

You talk to Claude in plain English, the way you'd talk to a sharp office manager. You don't need to know what a "connector" or "agent" is to use one — you just describe what you need done.

Start with one annoying task, let it earn your trust, and add more when you're ready. You already know the hard part — the work.

Questions about putting any of this to work?
That's what we do. — Takeoff Monkey,
takeoffmonkey.com

